

sick at the thought of an unexpected expense, even though we'd have plenty of cash to cover a new boiler or whatever,' she says. 'As kids, when something went wrong with the house or the car, the panic was real. I still run through disaster situations in my head about how things might go wrong, and I can't afford to fix it.'

Most of us have heard, in some way or another, of body dysmorphia: people whose image in the mirror is distorted in some way or another, which gives them a warped and difficult relationship with their body. In an episode of the fantastic *In Good Company*⁴ podcast, host Otegha Uwagba talks to her guest, artist and data journalist Mona Chalabi, about 'money dysmorphia' – the idea that experiences from our past can colour our relationship with money so deeply that we stop being able to tell what the real lay of the land actually is. This dissonance means that it's possible to know, logically, that you can afford something, but that there is always a voice telling you that you might need that money for something else – that there might still not be enough. Chalabi also wrote an article about this for the *Guardian* in 2019, entitled: 'Why I can't let myself have nice things'.⁵ Chalabi writes that she is unable to recognise the fact that she has money, even though she knows objectively that this is the case. She describes hesitating to order an expensive burger in a restaurant, even though she knows she can comfortably do so. 'But still,' she writes, 'I'll sit at the table stewing with anxiety over what I might need that money for someday. My warped reality